

The Florist's *Companion*.

A condensed revision guide to the craft, science and business of working with cut flowers — from stem to shopfront.

CHAPTERS

10

QUICK CHECKS

30

KEY TERMS

120+

FORMAT

Scan & revise

The Florist's World

What floristry actually is, the long history behind it, and what the modern florist is asked to do.

— Defining the craft

MODULE REFERENCE • F1, A1

Floristry is the *cultivation, care, handling, design, arrangement, retailing, production, display and delivery* of flowers and plants. It is both a creative art and a practical trade — requiring botanical knowledge, business skills and human sensitivity in equal measure.

<i>Cultivation</i>	Growing and producing flowers for commercial use.
<i>Handling & care</i>	Conditioning, storing and maintaining stock to maximise vase life.
<i>Floral design</i>	Creating arrangements, bouquets, tributes and displays.
<i>Retailing</i>	Selling direct to consumers — in-store, online or at events.
<i>Production</i>	Bulk preparation for weddings, corporate clients and large events.
<i>Delivery</i>	Transporting finished arrangements to homes, venues and businesses.

— A very short history

C. 2500 BCE

Ancient Egypt

Flower garlands and lotus arrangements appear in tomb paintings and funerary artefacts — used to honour the dead and mark important moments.

ANTIQUITY

Greece & Rome

Wreaths of laurel, olive and flowers worn at celebrations, victories and religious ceremonies.

MEDIEVAL

Strewing herbs

Flowers and herbs strewn on floors for fragrance and hygiene; herbal symbolism becomes formalised.

1837–1901

Victorian floriography

The peak "language of flowers" era — every bloom carrying a coded meaning exchanged in bouquets.

20TH CENTURY

Commercialisation

Industrial trade, refrigerated transport and the rise of the Dutch flower auctions.

TODAY

Sustainable & digital

Dried flowers, foraged design, local-grown movements, social media and direct-to-consumer e-commerce.

— What a florist actually does

CORE RESPONSIBILITIES – DAILY AND SEASONAL

- ☐ Design and create arrangements for a wide range of occasions
- ☐ Condition, process and care for incoming stock daily
- ☐ Consult with clients on needs, budget and preferences
- ☐ Source from wholesale suppliers and markets
- ☐ Manage stock, minimise waste and maintain a clean workspace
- ☐ Handle pricing, invoicing and financial transactions
- ☐ Coordinate time-sensitive deliveries (weddings, funerals)
- ☐ Stay current with trends, seasonal availability and new varieties
- ☐ Market the business – social media, in-store, word of mouth

PERSONAL QUALITIES OF A SUCCESSFUL FLORIST

Creativity	Designing beautifully from a wide range of materials.
Physical stamina	Long hours standing, carrying buckets, early starts.
Attention to detail	Precision in wiring, tying, colour-matching and proportion.
Customer empathy	Reading the emotion behind every purchase – grief, celebration, romance.
Organisation	Juggling multiple orders, deliveries and expectations simultaneously.
Botanical knowledge	Flower names, care requirements, seasonality and characteristics.
Business acumen	Pricing, marketing, buying and financial management.

* CAREER NOTE

Floristry frequently involves travel – weddings, christenings, corporate events. If you enjoy variety and working in different settings, it suits you well.

Q1 *Name three of the eight activities that the definition of floristry covers.*

Any three of: cultivation, care, handling, design, arrangement, retailing, production, display, delivery.

Q2 *Which Victorian-era practice gave every flower a coded meaning?*

Floriography – the "language of flowers" – at its peak between 1837 and 1901.

Q3 *Why is customer empathy considered a core florist skill, not just a "nice to have"?*

Because the purchase is almost always tied to a strong emotion – bereavement, romance, apology, celebration. Reading the emotion correctly shapes the design and the service.

Botany & *Identification*

Plant anatomy, the headline cut flowers, the foliage you will use weekly, and the difference between the names you say to a customer and the ones you order in.

— Why identification matters

Identifying a plant correctly lets you give it the right care, advise customers accurately, avoid mishandling toxic species, order the right stock and build professional credibility. A florist who knows their flowers by *both common and botanical name* stands apart from the competition.

— Plant anatomy — the working vocabulary

<i>Roots</i>	Anchor the plant; absorb water and nutrients from the soil.
<i>Stem</i>	Transports water and nutrients; provides structural support.
<i>Node</i>	Point on the stem where leaves, branches or flowers emerge.
<i>Internode</i>	Section of stem between two nodes.
<i>Leaf</i>	Photosynthesis organ — produces food from sunlight and CO ₂ .
<i>Bud</i>	Undeveloped flower or shoot, enclosed in protective sepals.
<i>Sepal (Calyx)</i>	Outer protective leafy covering around the bud.
<i>Petal (Corolla)</i>	The coloured display organs that attract pollinators.
<i>Stamen</i>	Male reproductive part — filament + anther (produces pollen).
<i>Pistil</i>	Female reproductive part — stigma + style + ovary.
<i>Receptacle</i>	Thickened end of the stem on which the flower parts sit.

* FLORIST APPLICATION — STEMS

Hollow stems (delphiniums, gerberas) need extra support in water. **Woody stems** (roses, lilac) need angled cuts and sometimes splitting. **Milky-sapped stems** (euphorbias, poppies) need searing to seal the latex before arranging.

— Cut flowers — identification at a glance

Rosa (<i>Rose</i>)	5-petalled or multi-petalled; thorned stems; widest colour range; most versatile cut flower.
Lilium (<i>Lily</i>)	Six large petals, prominent stamens with orange pollen; trumpet or bowl-shaped.
Helianthus (<i>Sunflower</i>)	Large golden ray petals around a dark disc; tall, coarse stems.
Tulipa (<i>Tulip</i>)	Cup-shaped; six petals; smooth, waxy stem — keeps growing after cutting.
Paeonia (<i>Peony</i>)	Lush, multi-layered, fragrant; rounded buds that open dramatically.
Gerbera	Daisy-like; bold single-colour ray petals; hollow stems — prone to drooping.
Chrysanthemum	Button, spray and single varieties; long-lasting; strong scent.
Orchid (<i>Phalaenopsis</i>)	Waxy, exotic; three petals + three sepals; extremely long-lasting; tropical.
Dahlia	Spherical or pompom forms; vast colour range; autumn star.
Anthurium	Glossy, waxy spathe; tropical; vase life of 3+ weeks.
Iris	Three upright "standards" + three falling "falls"; sword-like leaves.
Dianthus (<i>Carnation</i>)	Friiled petals; spicy clove scent; very long vase life.
Freesia	Funnel-shaped blooms on arching stems; intensely fragrant.
Alstroemeria	Multiple small blooms per stem; streaked inner petals; excellent value.
Lisianthus	Ruffled, rose-like petals in purple, white or pink; elegant.

— Foliage & filler — the supporting cast

Eucalyptus	Silver-grey, fragrant; seeded, gunnii and spiral forms.
Ruscus	Dark, stiff green leaves; robust; long-lasting; great structure.
Asparagus fern	Feathery, delicate texture; light and airy effect.
Bear grass	Long, slender blades; creates movement and line.
Pittosporum	Dense, variegated or dark; covers foam edges beautifully.
Ivy (<i>Hedera</i>)	Trailing; adds movement and romance.
Gypsophila	Tiny white/pink flowers; soft, cloud-like filler.
Wax flower (<i>Chamelaucium</i>)	Star-shaped; fragrant; pink, white, mauve.
Limonium (<i>Statice</i>)	Papery clusters; holds colour when dried.
Solidago	Yellow plumes — warmth and texture; very long-lasting.

— Common ↔ Botanical names

Use **common names** with customers, **botanical (Latin) names** when ordering or speaking professionally.

Rose	Rosa	Lily	Lilium
Sunflower	Helianthus annuus	Tulip	Tulipa
Peony	Paeonia	Carnation	Dianthus
Chrysanthemum	Dendranthema	Baby's breath	Gypsophila
Wax flower	Chamelaucium	Statice	Limonium
Speedwell	Veronica	Lemon leaf	Salal

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 02*

Q1 *Label the female reproductive parts of a flower.*

The pistil – stigma (sticky tip), style (the column) and ovary (the base).

Q2 *Why is the difference between a node and an internode useful at the workbench?*

It tells you where leaves come from (the node) and where you can safely cut without disturbing growth points. Cuts are typically made just above an internode.

Q3 *Give the botanical names for: sunflower, baby's breath, wax flower.*

Helianthus annuus, *Gypsophila*, *Chamelaucium*.

Q4 *Which three stem types each need a different treatment, and what is it?*

Hollow → fill with water + plug, or use narrow vase support. Woody → scrape or split the bottom 2–3 cm. Milky/latex → sear the cut end over a flame or in boiling water to seal the latex.

Flower Meanings

Floriography — the language of flowers — and the colour code beneath it. A thoughtfully chosen bloom communicates care and expertise.

— Why symbolism matters

Florists who understand the meaning behind each bloom stand apart. Whether for weddings, funerals or everyday gifting, the right flower carries an additional emotional layer the giver may not be able to articulate themselves.

— Flowers & their meanings

Red rose	Deep romantic love, passion, respect.
White rose	Purity, innocence, new beginnings, sympathy.
Yellow rose	Friendship, joy, caring — not romantic love.
Pink rose	Gratitude, admiration, gentleness.
White lily	Purity, mourning, sympathy — the traditional funeral flower.
Orange lily	Confidence, pride, passion.
Sunflower	Adoration, loyalty, warmth, positivity.
Red carnation	Deep love, admiration.
White carnation	Pure love, good luck.
Pink carnation	Maternal love — popular for Mother's Day.
Lavender	Calm, devotion, serenity.
Chrysanthemum	Longevity and loyalty (East Asia); grief (some European cultures).
Daisy	Innocence, purity, new beginnings.
Orchid	Luxury, beauty, strength, exoticism.
Red tulip	Perfect love, declaration of love.
Daffodil	Rebirth, hope, new starts — strongly linked to spring.
Forget-me-not	True love, remembrance, faithfulness.
Iris	Wisdom, hope, trust, courage.

— Colour symbolism



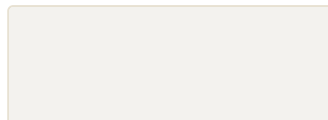
Red

Love, passion,
romance, energy.



Pink

Sweetness, gratitude,
admiration.



White

Purity, peace, sympathy,
beginnings.



Yellow

Happiness, friendship,
optimism.



Purple

Royalty, mystery,
remembrance.



Orange

Enthusiasm, creativity,
warmth.



Blue

Calm, trust, serenity
(rare in nature).



Green

Growth, harmony, health,
renewal.



Coral

Desire, enthusiasm;
romantic events.

△ CULTURAL NOTE

Always check cultural context. Chrysanthemums signal grief in France and Italy but are celebratory in China and Japan. White flowers mean mourning in some Asian cultures and purity in Western ones. Ask before assuming.

— Flowers for specific occasions

Weddings

Roses (love), peonies (romance, prosperity), lily of the valley (happiness), stephanotis (marital bliss).

THEME • JOY & PROMISE

Funerals

White lilies (peace), chrysanthemums (grief), white roses (remembrance), gladioli (integrity).

THEME • SYMPATHY

Mother's Day

Pink carnations, pink roses, daffodils, freesia.

THEME • MATERNAL LOVE

Valentine's Day

Red roses, red tulips, red carnations.

THEME • PASSION

Get Well Soon

Sunflowers (positivity), daisies (cheer), gerberas (brightness).

THEME • LIFT THE ROOM

New baby

Soft pink/blue blooms, gypsophila, sweet peas.

THEME • GENTLE WELCOME

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 03*

Q1 *A customer asks for yellow roses for a partner's anniversary. What might you check before processing the order?*

Yellow roses mean friendship and joy — not romantic love. Confirm the customer's intent without alarming them, in case red, pink or peach roses better suit the message.

Q2 *Which flower symbolises remembrance and faithfulness?*

Forget-me-not.

Q3 *Why might chrysanthemums be a poor choice for a celebration arrangement in France?*

In France and Italy chrysanthemums are strongly associated with grief and funerals. They would not feel celebratory.

Care & Conditioning

Keeping flowers alive, healthy and beautiful for as long as possible — and the invisible threats that shorten their life.

— Why care matters commercially

A florist's profitability depends on minimising waste. Every additional day of vase life is more value out of every stem purchased. Correct conditioning, storage and an understanding of ethylene are what separate professional florists from amateurs.

— Post-harvest care, step by step

- 01 **Receive & inspect.** Check all incoming stock; remove damaged or diseased stems immediately.
- 02 **Re-cut stems.** Cut at a 45° angle with a clean, sharp knife — under water if possible.
- 03 **De-leaf.** Strip every leaf that will sit below the waterline to prevent bacterial growth.
- 04 **Hydrate.** Place straight into clean buckets of fresh water with flower food at the correct dilution.
- 05 **Condition.** Allow 1–4 hours in a cool, dark environment to "drink up" before use.
- 06 **Store.** 1–5 °C commercially, away from sunlight, heat and draughts.
- 07 **Maintain.** Re-cut stems and refresh water every 2–3 days.

✦ GOLDEN RULE

Always cut stems at a **45° angle**. This increases the surface area for water uptake and prevents the stem end from sitting flat on the bottom of the bucket — which would block absorption entirely.

— What is actually in flower food?

Sugar	Carbohydrate energy for continued petal development.
Acidifier (<i>citric acid</i>)	Lowers water pH to improve uptake through stem xylem.
Biocide (<i>bleach / antimicrobial</i>)	Kills bacteria that block stem vessels and cloud the water.

* DILUTION TIP

Never mix flower food stronger than the manufacturer recommends — too much can burn stems. Follow the ratio on the sachet.

— Ethylene — the invisible flower enemy

Ethylene (C₂H₄) is a naturally occurring plant hormone in gas form that accelerates ripening, ageing and deterioration. It is colourless, odourless and present in everyday environments — making it one of the most overlooked threats in floristry.

What it does	Triggers petal drop, premature opening, yellowing leaves, wilting.
Natural sources	Ripening fruit (especially apples, bananas, pears), ageing flowers, car exhausts.
In the shop	Fruit bowls near flowers; composting waste left close to stock.
In transport	Enclosed vans with ripe produce; poorly ventilated vehicles.
Prevention	Keep flowers away from fruit; remove dying stems promptly; ventilate well.
Commercial treatment	Ethylene inhibitors (EthylBloc / 1-MCP) used to prolong vase life.

△ HIGH-RISK FLOWERS

The most ethylene-sensitive blooms to watch carefully: **carnations, sweet peas, delphinium, freesia, gypsophila and lisianthus**. Keep these well away from fruit and decaying plant material.

— Common problems & quick fixes

Wilting stems	Re-cut; submerge stem ends in boiling water 20 sec then plunge into cold (woody/milky).
Drooping gerbera	Support stems in shallow water; use narrow-necked vase; avoid overcrowding.
Tulips bending	Normal — they keep growing. Keep in cool, shallow water; use a straight-sided container.
Roses won't open	Warm room; re-cut; add sugar to water; remove outer guard petals.
Cloudy water	Change water; clean container; check no foliage is submerged.
Pollen stains	Remove lily anthers as buds open. Don't rub stains — let dry, then brush off.
Yellowing leaves	Ethylene exposure / overwatering / too warm. Improve ventilation and temperature.
Botrytis (grey mould)	Fungal — remove affected material; improve air circulation; lower humidity.

— Special stem types

Woody (<i>roses, lilac, stocks</i>)	Scrape or split the bottom 2–3 cm of stem to aid water uptake.
Hollow (<i>delphinium, lupin</i>)	Invert, fill with water, plug with cotton wool, then place in vase.
Milky / latex (<i>euphorbia, poppy</i>)	Sear cut end over flame or in boiling water for 20 seconds to seal the latex.
Bulb (<i>tulip, daffodil</i>)	Do not mix daffodils with other flowers — they release toxic sap. Condition separately.

△ CRITICAL WARNING • DAFFODILS

Never mix daffodils (narcissi) directly with other flowers. Their stems release a slimy sap (calcium oxalate) that is toxic to most other blooms. Condition them separately for 24 hours first, then rinse the stems before combining.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 04*

Q1 *List the three active ingredients in commercial flower food and what each does.*

Sugar — energy for petals. Acidifier (citric acid) — lowers pH for better uptake. Biocide — kills bacteria in the water.

Q2 *Why is a bowl of bananas next to a bucket of carnations a disaster?*

Ripening bananas release ethylene gas; carnations are among the most ethylene-sensitive flowers and will drop petals and wilt rapidly.

Q3 *A bunch of euphorbia is bleeding white sap onto your bench. What's the safe treatment?*

Sear the cut end over a flame or briefly in boiling water for ~20 seconds to seal the latex before arranging.

Q4 *A customer's roses won't open. Name two things they can do at home.*

Move them to a warmer room, re-cut the stems, add a little sugar to the water, and gently remove the outer guard petals.

Processing & Storage

The professional procedures for receiving, storing and maintaining stock in a working shop or studio.

— Processing incoming stock

When fresh flowers arrive, the clock is already ticking. Correct processing in the *first hour* is the single most impactful thing you can do to extend vase life.

- ☐ Unpack immediately — never leave flowers wrapped in plastic in a warm space
- ☐ Inspect for botrytis, wilting, breakage and wrong varieties
- ☐ Remove sleeves, bands and packing paper (keep cool-chain packaging on until ready)
- ☐ Re-cut stems at 45° — remove at least 2–3 cm from each
- ☐ Strip all leaves that would sit below the waterline
- ☐ Place in clean buckets with fresh water + flower food at correct dilution
- ☐ Condition 1–4 hours in a cool, dark space before display

— Storage conditions by flower type

Cut flowers (<i>general</i>)	1–5 °C; 90–95% RH; away from ethylene sources.
Tropical (<i>orchids, anthuriums</i>)	10–15 °C minimum. Never refrigerate — chilling-sensitive.
Bulb (<i>tulips, daffodils</i>)	2–5 °C; keep separate (daffodil sap); cut short — they keep growing.
Potted plants	Room temp 15–20 °C; good light; water regularly; not in a cooler.
Dried flowers	Cool, dry, dark; low humidity to prevent mould; no water at all.
Foliage	1–5 °C; can last 1–2 weeks with regular stem re-cuts.

⚠ TEMPERATURE WARNING

Tropical flowers — orchids, anthuriums, bird of paradise — are **chilling-sensitive**. Refrigerating below 10 °C will cause irreversible cold damage. They blacken and collapse. Store at room temperature.

— Preservatives & additives — what works

Chrysal / Floralife	The gold standard — sugar + acidifier + biocide. Always use.
Bleach (a few drops/litre)	Kills bacteria; use as emergency when flower food unavailable.
Aspirin	Mild acidifier; marginally helpful; not as effective as proper preservative.
Clear lemonade	Sugar + citric acid — rough emergency preservative only.
Vodka / spirits	Inhibits ethylene production slightly; unreliable; not recommended.
Copper coin	An old wives' tale. Doesn't work — don't recommend to customers.

— Maintaining a retail display

- **Daily.** Check water levels; remove dead stems; re-cut and refresh.
- **Rotation.** Older stock to the front, fresh to the back ("first in, first out").
- **Temperature.** Shop floor ideally below 18 °C; avoid heat vents.
- **Misting.** Lightly mist tropical foliage and humidity-loving flowers (hydrangea).
- **Lighting.** Avoid prolonged direct sunlight — UV accelerates ageing.
- **Hygiene.** Disinfect buckets between uses; bacteria are the primary cause of early wilting.
- **Stock rotation.** Never mix fresh stock with older stock in the same bucket.

— Professional products to know

Floralife / Chrysal preservative	Added to water — the industry-standard care product.
Aquapack (bud sachet)	Miniature water capsule for individual stems in transit.
Stem sealant (wax / resin)	Seals the cut end to slow drying — used in dried or gift bouquets.
Leaf shine spray	Adds a glossy finish to robust foliage.
Anti-transpirant spray	Reduces moisture loss from petals and foliage — used before events.
1-MCP (EthylBloc)	Commercial ethylene inhibitor; used in large-scale storage.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 05*

Q1 *A delivery of phalaenopsis orchids arrives at 8am. Where do you put them?*

Room temperature (10–15 °C minimum). They are chilling-sensitive – refrigerating them will blacken and ruin them.

Q2 *A junior re-uses yesterday's bucket without disinfecting it. Why does this matter?*

Bacteria from the previous water multiply in the new bucket, block the stem xylem and dramatically shorten vase life. Hygiene is the primary lever on flower longevity.

Q3 *Why are tulips stored cut short?*

Tulips continue to grow after cutting; if stored too long they outgrow the vase or arrangement and bend.

Design Principles

The elements, the principles, the styles. What turns a bunch of flowers into a meaningful, balanced arrangement.

— The seven elements of floral design

Line	Directs the eye; creates movement and structure.
Form	The three-dimensional shape of the arrangement and individual blooms.
Space	The empty areas — negative space gives a design room to breathe.
Texture	Surface quality — rough vs smooth, matte vs shiny.
Colour	The most impactful element; evokes emotion and sets mood.
Size / Scale	Proportional relationships between flowers, container and setting.
Pattern	Repetition of elements that creates visual rhythm.

— The six principles of floral design

Balance	Visual equality — symmetrical or asymmetrical.
Proportion	Correct size relationships. Rule of thumb: arrangement $\approx 1.5 \times$ container height.
Dominance	One element (colour, flower type) leads; the others support.
Rhythm	Movement created by repetition and transition of elements.
Contrast	Differences in colour, texture or form that create interest.
Unity / Harmony	All elements working together as a cohesive whole.

— Western design styles

<i>Round / Mass</i> Symmetrical globe; classic and formal.	<i>Triangular</i> Structured; traditional European; formal.	<i>Crescent</i> C-shaped; elegant; gifts and events.
<i>Hogarth Curve</i> S-curve; graceful; formal settings.	<i>Vertical</i> Tall, linear, dramatic; suits tall vases.	<i>Horizontal</i> Low and wide; perfect for centrepieces.
<i>Parallel</i> Multiple upright groupings; modern.	<i>Biedermeier</i> Concentric rings of single flower types.	<i>Mille de Fleur</i> Many tiny flowers; romantic and lush.

— Eastern design — Ikebana

Ikebana — Japanese for *living flowers* — is the ancient Japanese art of arrangement, developed over 600 years. Its philosophy differs fundamentally from Western design.

Core philosophy	Simplicity, minimalism, harmony with nature.
Key principle	Negative space is as important as the flowers.
Three main lines	Heaven (<i>shin</i>), Man (<i>soe</i>), Earth (<i>hikae</i>) — each set at a defined angle.
Asymmetry	Deliberately unbalanced; mirrors nature's imperfection.
Spiritual dimension	Arrangement as meditation; connection between arranger and nature.
Schools	Ikenobo (oldest), Ohara, Sogetsu.

* I K E B A N A K E Y

Far fewer stems than Western design. Three stems alone can create a complete, balanced arrangement — the space between them is considered part of the work.

— Colour theory for florists

Monochromatic	One hue in varying shades and tints — elegant, sophisticated.
Analogous	Adjacent colours on the wheel — harmonious and natural.
Complementary	Opposite colours — high contrast and vibrancy (e.g. purple & yellow).
Triadic	Three equidistant colours — bold and energetic.
Warm palette	Reds, oranges, yellows — energising, passionate, celebratory.
Cool palette	Blues, purples, whites — calming, peaceful, serene.

* COLOUR MOOD TIP

Naturally soothing colours include lavender, soft pink and pale blue. Bright orange near red can feel overwhelming. Always weigh the emotional impact of your palette against the occasion.

— Step-by-step · a basic round arrangement

01 **Prepare your container** with wet floral foam or fresh water.

02 **Establish height and width** with your tallest stems first.

03 **Add foliage** for a base outline that covers any foam edges.

04 **Place focal flowers** first — odd numbers look natural.

05 **Add secondary flowers** to fill in and support focals.

06 **Fill gaps** with filler (gypsophila, wax flower).

07 **Step back and rotate** — check balance from every angle.

08 **Mist lightly** and display away from direct heat.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 06*

Q1 *What is the rule-of-thumb proportion between an arrangement's height and its container?*

The arrangement should be roughly $1.5 \times$ the container's height for pleasing proportion.

Q2 *Name the three main lines of Ikebana and what they represent.*

Shin (Heaven), Soe (Man), Hikae (Earth) – each placed at a defined angle to suggest the cosmos in miniature.

Q3 *A client wants a "high-contrast, vibrant" palette. Which colour scheme fits?*

Complementary – opposite colours on the wheel, e.g. purple and yellow, or orange and blue.

Q4 *Why are focal flowers placed before secondary flowers, and why odd numbers?*

Focals anchor the design; everything else is sized and placed in relation to them. Odd numbers create asymmetric tension that reads as natural rather than mechanical.

Containers & *Mechanics*

The vessel is part of the design — and the mechanics inside it are what hold the design together. Tools, supports and display considerations.

— Choosing a container

Before you commit to a container, ask: **where will this be displayed, what mood should it convey, and does it complement the flowers** in colour, texture and scale?

Clear glass vase	Shows off stems; suits modern, minimalist styles.
Opaque ceramic	Hides stems; adds formality and colour.
Tall cylinder	Modern; long-stemmed single varieties.
Bud vase (slim)	Single stems; contemporary; often grouped in sets.
Bowl / low dish	Compact centrepieces; foam-based.
Urn / pedestal	Formal, classical; large-scale event work.
Pitcher / jug	Informal, charming; wildflowers and garden blooms.
Wicker basket	Rustic country feel; lined with plastic to hold water.
Wooden crate / box	Industrial-rustic; great for market styles.
Terracotta pot	Earthy; wildflower or herb arrangements.
Bottle / jam jar	Casual, vintage; perfect for informal gifting.
Lantern / cage	Decorative; arrangements placed inside or woven through.

— Mechanics — holding stems in place

- **Floral foam (Oasis)**. Soak thoroughly before use; never re-wet dry foam.
- **Chicken wire**. Crumpled in the neck of a vase for stem support — eco-friendly alternative to foam.
- **Pin frogs / kenzan**. Japanese flower frogs; metal spikes that hold stems vertically; ideal for Ikebana.
- **Tape grid**. Clear tape criss-crossed over a vase opening for invisible support.
- **Binding wire**. For bouquets, corsages and any wired design work.
- **Waterproof floral tape**. Securing foam, sealing cut wounds, wrapping wires.

* F O A M T I P

Let floral foam float on water until it sinks under its own weight. Never push it under — forced soaking creates air pockets that prevent water uptake.

— Essential tools — beginner kit

- ☐ **Floral knife** — clean angled stem cuts
- ☐ **Stem cutters / snips** — precision cutting without crushing
- ☐ **Wire cutters** — for floral wire work
- ☐ **Floral foam (Oasis)** — holds stems in position when wet
- ☐ **Binding wire** — secures stems and bouquet shapes
- ☐ **Ribbon & tape** — finishing and securing hand-ties
- ☐ **Buckets of water** — immediate hydration after cutting

— Display considerations

- **Viewing angle.** Round vase (all sides) vs one-sided arrangement.
- **Height.** Centrepieces should never block sightlines across a table.
- **Light.** Natural light enhances colour; avoid direct sunlight.
- **Temperature.** Away from radiators, open fires, A/C vents.
- **Background.** Consider wall colour and surroundings against your palette.
- **Event context.** A formal dinner, a casual party and a church ceremony each demand a different scale.

— Arrangement type · matching container

Hand-tied bouquet	No container — stems are the structure; wrapped in paper or ribbon.
Corsage / boutonnière	No container — wired and taped to be worn on the body.
Table centrepiece	Low bowl, bud vases, lantern, wooden slice.
Altar / church arrangement	Pedestal urn, large ceramic, column vase.
Sympathy tribute	Open frame, wreath frame, foam shape (heart, cross, letters).
Basket arrangement	Lined wicker basket with foam block.
Hanging arrangement	Wire frame, moss-lined structure, suspended foam.

Q1 *A customer wants an eco-friendly alternative to floral foam. What do you suggest?*

Crumpled chicken wire inside the vase neck, or a pin frog (kenzan) at the base, or a clear tape grid across the opening.

Q2 *How do you correctly soak a brick of floral foam?*

Float it on water and let it sink under its own weight. Never push it under — forced soaking traps air pockets.

Q3 *A dining-table centrepiece feels too tall. Why is that a problem?*

It blocks sightlines across the table and makes conversation difficult — centrepieces should be low or use elevated vessels with airy stems above eye level.

Wedding Floristry

One of the most rewarding and demanding areas of the craft. Every detail carries sentimental weight and must reflect the couple's vision.

— The wedding florist's role

A wedding florist is consultant, designer and project manager. You translate a couple's vision into floral reality – managing a budget, coordinating with other vendors and delivering flawlessly on the day.

- ☐ Hold a detailed consultation – vision, theme, budget
- ☐ Understand the wedding colour palette, dress style and venue aesthetics
- ☐ Research flower availability and seasonal considerations for the date
- ☐ Provide a detailed, itemised quote
- ☐ Coordinate delivery and setup times with the venue
- ☐ Plan contingencies for flower substitutions if stock fails

— Symbolic flowers for weddings

Rose	Love and romance – the classic wedding flower.
Peony	Prosperity, happiness, romance – hugely popular.
Lily of the Valley	Happiness, humility – traditionally bridal.
Stephanotis	Marital bliss, good luck – often wired into bouquets.
Freesia	Trust, innocence, thoughtfulness.
Ranunculus	Charm, attractiveness – layers of delicate petals.
Lavender	Devotion, calm, purity.
Gypsophila	Innocence, eternal love, sincerity.
Sweet Pea	Delicate pleasure, blissful memory.

— Types of bridal bouquet

Round / Posy

Classic, compact, rounded.
Holds itself naturally —
most versatile.

VERSATILITY • HIGH

Cascade / Shower

Trailing downward; romantic
and traditional; suits
formal dresses.

DRAMA • HIGH

Hand-tied / Natural

Relaxed, organic, garden-
feel; no wire or foam.

STYLE • LOOSE

Structured / wired

Every stem individually
wired for maximum
control; heavier.

STYLE • FORMAL

Single stem

Minimalist; one perfect
bloom; elegant.

STYLE • MODERN

Composite (Glamellia)

Multiple petals assembled
into one giant bloom;
labour-intensive.

SKILL • HIGH

Nosegay

Small, tightly packed posy;
bridesmaids or flower girls.

SIZE • SMALL

— Key wedding floral elements

- **Bridal bouquet** — the focal piece; reflects the entire floral theme.
- **Bridesmaid bouquets** — complementary but smaller / simpler.
- **Boutonnière / buttonhole** — for groom and male attendants; single bloom plus foliage.
- **Corsages** — for mothers and special guests; wrist or pin-on.
- **Flower girl accessories** — halo crowns, pomander balls, petal baskets.
- **Ceremony décor** — altar arrangements, aisle pew ends, arch / arbour.
- **Reception centrepieces** — must not block sightlines.
- **Top table arrangement** — usually the grandest centrepiece on the day.
- **Cake flowers** — fresh or dried; always check edibility / safety.
- **Venue dressing** — entrance pieces, hanging installations, bar décor.

* BRIDAL TIP

Sentimental flower meanings matter greatly to couples. A bride might want lily of the valley because her grandmother carried it, or peonies because they grew in her childhood garden. Always ask about personal connections to flowers.

— UK seasonal availability

Spring (Mar–May)	Tulips, daffodils, lily of the valley, ranunculus, hellebore, blossom branches; late peonies.
Summer (Jun–Aug)	Peonies, sweet peas, roses, lavender, freesia, cornflowers.
Autumn (Sep–Nov)	Dahlias, sunflowers, chrysanthemums, berries, rose hips, cosmos.
Winter (Dec–Feb)	Amaryllis, hellebore, poinsettia, eucalyptus, mistletoe, forced tulips.
Year-round (imported)	Roses, carnations, lilies, gerbera, alstroemeria, orchids, gypsophila.

* SEASON NOTE

Out-of-season flowers can still be sourced but cost considerably more and may be lower quality. Always discuss seasonality with clients early when building their budget.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 08*

Q1 *A couple wants peonies for a February wedding. What do you tell them?*

Peonies are a spring/early-summer flower in the UK. In February they would need to be imported at significantly higher cost and lower quality, or substituted with similar-feel blooms (garden roses, ranunculus, double tulips). Suggest options early in the consultation.

Q2 *What does stephanotis traditionally symbolise, and where might you use it?*

Marital bliss and good luck — often wired individually into bridal bouquets.

Q3 *Why is a contingency plan for stock substitution essential at every wedding?*

Wholesale supply is variable — varieties, quality, sizes and colours all fluctuate. A pre-agreed list of acceptable substitutes lets you deliver on the day without panicked client phone calls.

Sympathy & Funeral

One of the most meaningful and sensitive areas of floristry. Sympathy flowers offer comfort and honour a life lived.

— The emotional context

Grieving families experience confusion, sadness and overwhelm alongside their loss. As a florist you must be calm, compassionate and clear in your guidance. Never minimise the importance of their choices — every arrangement is part of how they say goodbye.

* EMPATHY FIRST

If a family seems confused or distressed about flower choices, gently guide them. Suggest a small number of popular options and explain their meanings briefly. Avoid overwhelming them with too many choices.

— Popular sympathy flowers & meanings

White lily	The most common funeral flower — purity, restored innocence of the soul.
Chrysanthemum	Widely used in Europe for sympathy; longevity, loyalty.
White rose	Reverence, humility, innocence, remembrance.
Gladioli	Strength of character, integrity, sincerity — often in sprays.
Carnation (white/pink)	Pure love, undying remembrance.
Orchid	Eternal love, strength; long-lasting for the home after the service.
Freesia	Innocence, trust, thoughtfulness.
Forget-me-not	Remembrance, undying love, true affection.
Hyacinth	Constancy — "I will pray for you"; peaceful.

— Types of funeral tribute

Coffin spray

Arranged directly on the coffin lid; long, one-sided.

Casket arrangement

Similar to coffin spray; follows the coffin shape.

Wreath (round)

Circular; symbolises eternity and the cycle of life.

Sheaf / open sheaf

Loose, natural bouquet laid flat; elegant and informal.

Heart

Wire frame covered with flowers; symbol of love.

Cross

Wire frame; used in Christian services.

Cushion

Square or round padded foam base; letters or images on top.

Letters / words

Floral letters spelling "DAD", "MUM", a name.

Posy / hand-tied

Small personal bouquet; often placed inside the coffin.

— Etiquette & traditions

- Always ask about the religion and cultural background of the deceased and family.
- Some religions discourage cut flowers (e.g. some Jewish traditions prefer charitable donations).
- Many funerals specify "family flowers only" — direct others to send to the home afterwards.
- Colour traditionally white and cream — modern funerals may request colour.
- Always include a florist's card with every tribute. Never assume it will be clear who sent it.
- Deliver directly to the funeral home unless requested otherwise — **not** to the family home the day before.
- Tributes should arrive at least one hour before the service.
- Condolence flowers sent to the home (after the funeral) should be cheerful and uplifting.

— Making a wreath · key steps

- 01 **Start** with a foam or straw wreath ring — soaked if using fresh flowers.
- 02 **Cover the base** with foliage (moss, eucalyptus, pittosporum) to create a green foundation.
- 03 **Add focal flowers** evenly around the ring, all facing the same direction.
- 04 **Fill gaps** with secondary flowers and filler.
- 05 **Finish** with ribbon, bow or a card holder.
- 06 **Mist and store cool** until delivery.

△ WREATH CARE

Foam wreath frames must stay moist. After construction, mist the arrangement and store in a cool place. Never leave in a hot car or direct sunlight on the day of delivery.

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 09*

- Q1 *A family says "family flowers only." Where do you direct others who still wish to send something?*
Direct them to send cheerful, uplifting arrangements to the family home *after* the service — not to the funeral itself.
- Q2 *What does a round wreath traditionally symbolise?*
Eternity and the cycle of life — its unbroken circle has no beginning or end.
- Q3 *A florist's card is missing from a delivered tribute. Why is this more than a small mistake?*
The family may not be able to identify who sent it and so cannot thank the sender. It looks unprofessional and damages relationships. Always attach a card to every tribute.

Business & Career

From your first Saturday job to opening your own shop. Pricing, marketing and the realities of making a living from flowers.

— Types of floristry service & business model

Full-service florist	Comprehensive – arrangements, bouquets, events, delivery, consultations.
Speciality florist	Niche – weddings only, corporate only, dried flowers, foraged.
Limited-service florist	Pre-made bouquets, walk-in only, no bespoke orders.
Flower seller	Market or stall; minimal design; sells stems and bunches.
Online florist	E-commerce focused; standardised products; nationwide or local delivery.
Studio / home florist	Works from home; event-focused; low overheads; flexible.
Supermarket / garage	Pre-packaged; convenience-led; no design consultation.

— Career pathways

Junior / Saturday florist

Entry-level; learn conditioning, wrapping and basics alongside experienced florists.

Qualified florist

Trained; full range of designs; may supervise juniors.

Senior / Head florist

Leads design direction; manages stock orders; mentors team.

Shop manager

Oversees operations, staff, finances, stock, customer service.

Freelance florist

Self-employed; takes contracts as needed; usually event-focused.

Wedding specialist

Focuses exclusively on weddings; portfolio + vendor relationships.

Funeral arranger

Often within a funeral home; specialised sympathy knowledge.

Corporate account manager

Manages contracts with hotels, venues, businesses.

Floristry teacher / tutor

Teaches at colleges or runs private workshops.

Flower farmer

Grows own cut flowers; sells direct to florists or public.

— What employers look for

- ☐ **Botanical knowledge** – identify common flowers and foliage by name
- ☐ **Conditioning skills** – understanding of care and post-harvest treatment
- ☐ **Design ability** – portfolio of work; even phone photos of home arrangements count
- ☐ **Customer service** – friendly, professional communication
- ☐ **Reliability** – punctuality, especially for time-sensitive events
- ☐ **Physical fitness** – standing, carrying buckets, early starts
- ☐ **Team player** – collaborative, especially at seasonal peaks
- ☐ **Enthusiasm** – genuine passion; employers train skills, not attitude

* JOB - HUNTING TIP

Even with no formal qualifications, a small portfolio of your own arrangements – photographed and presented on your phone – shows an employer your eye for design and your commitment to learning.

— UK training routes

Level 2 Award in Floristry (City & Guilds)	Entry-level; basic skills and knowledge.
Level 3 Certificate / Diploma	More advanced; suitable for employment or self-employment.
HND / Foundation Degree	Higher level; business and design combined; 1–2 years.
Apprenticeship	Earn while you learn; in-shop training combined with study.
Online courses	Flexible; good for theory and CPD; affordable.
Private floristry schools	Intensive practical courses; often London-based; prestigious.
On-the-job training	Working alongside an experienced florist; very practical.

— Pricing — the working formula

Cost of Goods (CoG)	Flowers + foliage + sundries (foam, wire, ribbon, wrap, tissue).
Labour	Your time designing, conditioning, packing, delivering.
Overheads	Rent, utilities, insurance, vehicle, subscriptions.
Profit margin	What remains — aim for a minimum of 30–40%.
Rule of thumb	Retail price = CoG × 3 as a starting baseline.
Event premium	Wedding and event work priced higher — covers consultation, travel, setup.

✦ PRICING REMINDER

Many new florists undercharge because they love the work and feel guilty charging for their time. Remember: if your business doesn't turn a profit, it will not survive. Your time has real monetary value — always include it.

— Marketing — the four principles

1 · Product	What are you selling? Define your offer clearly — what makes your floristry distinctive and desirable?
2 · Price	Must cover costs and communicate value. Underpricing signals low quality.
3 · Place	Where do customers find and buy from you? Shop, online, markets, events, delivery?
4 · Promotion	How do you reach customers? Social media, flyers, word of mouth, partnerships, advertising?

— Promotion channels — what to use

Instagram	Post 3–5×/week; high-quality photos; process + finished work; relevant hashtags.
Facebook	Business page + local groups; events; paid ads for seasonal peaks.
Google Business Profile	Free, essential for local search; collect five-star reviews proactively.
Word of mouth	The most powerful channel — deliver excellence every time.
Wedding fairs & expos	Meet potential wedding clients face-to-face; showcase your style.
Collaborations	Wedding planners, venues, photographers, funeral homes, hotels.
Email newsletter	Monthly updates; seasonal promotions; care tips; keeps past customers warm.
Website / blog	SEO-optimised; portfolio; online ordering; credibility.
Street presence	Window display, A-board outside the shop; attract passing trade.

— Peak revenue seasons — plan early

Valentine's Day (14 Feb)	Biggest single-day event for most florists. Order stock 3–4 weeks early.
Mother's Day (UK)	Second biggest. Pink carnations, roses, daffodils, mixed bouquets.
Christmas (Dec)	Wreaths, centrepieces, poinsettia, gift bouquets. Sustained demand all month.
Easter	Seasonal spring arrangements; daffodils, tulips, spring colours.
Wedding season (May–Sep)	Peak for events. Book venues early; hire help for busy weekends.
Funerals	Year-round and unpredictable. Maintain reliable turnaround capacity.

— Starting your own business — checklist

- ☐ Choose your model — retail shop, home studio, market stall, online, events
- ☐ Write a business plan — target market, pricing, startup costs, revenue forecasts
- ☐ Register the business — sole trader / limited company, HMRC, tax obligations
- ☐ Source suppliers — wholesale market, local growers, online auctions, cash-and-carry backup
- ☐ Set prices — $\text{CoG} \times 3$ minimum; always include your time and overheads
- ☐ Build your brand — name, logo, colours; consistent across all platforms
- ☐ Open online presence — Google Business Profile + Instagram before first sale
- ☐ Start small — grow gradually; reinvest profits; don't over-expand

— Building a brand

- **Consistency.** Same quality, same voice, same visual identity everywhere.
- **Photography.** Invest in good natural-light photos of every arrangement — this *is* your portfolio.
- **Story.** Customers connect with the person behind the flowers; share your why.
- **Niche.** Consider specialising — wild/foraged, sustainable, luxury events, dried.
- **Reviews.** Proactively ask every happy customer to leave a Google or Facebook review.
- **Packaging.** Branded tissue, stickers, care cards and ribbon create a premium experience.
- **Service.** Respond promptly. Go slightly beyond expectations. People remember how you made them feel.

— Professional standards

- Always be on time — especially for weddings and funerals.
- Dress and present professionally on client-facing days.
- Respond to enquiries within 24 hours.
- Never speak negatively about competitors.
- Build supplier relationships — reliability and loyalty matter.
- Keep up with trends via trade shows (New Covent Garden, Chelsea Flower Show).
- Consider professional body membership (e.g. British Florist Association).

KNOWLEDGE CHECK *Test yourself on Chapter 10*

Q1 *A bouquet's cost of goods is £18. What's a reasonable retail price as a starting point — and why?*

Around £54 ($\text{CoG} \times 3$). The multiplier covers labour, overheads and a 30–40% profit margin; anything less typically leaves the florist working for free.

Q2 *What are the four basic marketing principles ("the 4 Ps")?*

Product, Price, Place, Promotion.

Q3 *Why might commercial accounts be priced higher per arrangement than retail walk-ins, despite being repeat business?*

They demand guaranteed consistency, reliability and reservation of stock — a premium that covers the operational overhead of always being ready for them.

Q4 *Name the two minimum online channels to set up before taking your first paying order.*

A Google Business Profile (for local search and reviews) and an Instagram account (for portfolio and discovery).

Quick Reference

The one-page cheat sheets — for the moments before an exam, a delivery, or a difficult consultation.

Stem care — the four golden rules

- **Always cut at 45°**
Increases surface area for water uptake; keeps stem off bucket bottom.
- **Strip below waterline**
Submerged foliage rots and breeds bacteria fast.
- **Flower food in fresh water**
Sugar, acidifier, biocide — at the recommended dilution.
- **Cool, dark, no fruit**
1–5 °C for most flowers; ethylene-free environment.

Stem types — the special cases

- **Woody**
Scrape or split the bottom 2–3 cm.
- **Hollow**
Invert, fill with water, plug with cotton wool.
- **Milky / latex**
Sear for 20 sec to seal sap.
- **Daffodils**
Condition *alone* for 24 hours. Toxic sap.
- **Tropical**
Never refrigerate below 10 °C.
- **Bulb**
Keep cut short — they grow on.

Ethylene — the cheat sheet

- **What is it**
Plant hormone in gas form. Ages and ripens.
- **Sources**
Ripening fruit, decaying flowers, car exhaust.
- **Effects**
Petal drop, wilting, yellowing, premature opening.
- **Sensitive flowers**
Carnation, sweet pea, delphinium, freesia, gypsophila, lisianthus.
- **Prevention**
Ventilation; no fruit near stock; remove dying stems.
- **Commercial fix**
1-MCP (EthylBloc) inhibitor.

Design — elements, principles & styles

— 7 Elements

Line · Form · Space · Texture · Colour · Scale · Pattern.

— Western styles

Round, Triangular, Crescent, Hogarth, Vertical, Horizontal, Parallel, Biedermeier, Mille de Fleur.

— Proportion rule

Arrangement = $1.5 \times$ container height.

— 6 Principles

Balance · Proportion · Dominance · Rhythm · Contrast · Harmony.

— Ikebana lines

Shin (Heaven), Soe (Man), Hikae (Earth).

— Colour schemes

Monochromatic · Analogous · Complementary · Triadic.

Pricing — the formula

— Components

Cost of Goods + Labour + Overheads + Profit.

— Profit target

30–40% minimum margin.

— Commercial

Price for reliability and reserved capacity, not per stem.

— Rule of thumb

Retail price = $\text{CoG} \times 3$ (minimum).

— Events

Price higher — covers consult, travel, setup.

— Never

Skip pricing your own time.

Symbolism — *the essentials*

— Romance

Red rose, red tulip, red carnation, peony.

— Friendship

Yellow rose, sunflower, daisy.

— Remembrance

Forget-me-not, white rose, hyacinth.

— Sympathy

White lily, white rose, chrysanthemum, gladioli.

— Maternal love

Pink carnation, pink rose, freesia.

— Cultural caveat

Chrysanthemum reads as grief in France, joy in Japan. Always ask.

— Master terminology index

Anther Pollen sac on the stamen

Botrytis Grey mould fungal disease

Cascade Trailing bouquet style

Corolla The petals collectively

Ethylene Ageing plant hormone (gas)

Foam (Oasis) Wet stem support medium

Ikebana Japanese minimalist art

Mille de Fleur Many-flower lush style

Nosegay Small tight posy

Posy Small round bouquet

Sepal Outer leafy bud cover

Stamen Male part – filament+anther

Biocide Antibacterial in flower food

Calyx Outer sepals around a bud

Conditioning Hydrating new stems

Corsage Wired wearable flower piece

Floriography Language of flowers

Hogarth curve S-shaped arrangement

Kenzan Pin frog stem support

Node Where leaves emerge on stem

Pistil Female part – stigma+style+ovary

Receptacle Base of the flower head

Spray Multiple flowers per stem

Wreath Circular tribute frame

— Revision plan · one-week sprint

- ☐ **Day 1** — Read Chapters 1 & 2. Complete both knowledge checks.

- ☐ **Day 2** — Chapter 3 (meanings) + Chapter 4 (care). Drill the ethylene-sensitive list.

- ☐ **Day 3** — Chapter 5 (storage). Memorise temperature bands by flower type.

- ☐ **Day 4** — Chapter 6 (design). Sketch one example of each Western style.

- ☐ **Day 5** — Chapter 7 (containers). Tools quiz. Try a hand-tied bouquet.

- ☐ **Day 6** — Chapters 8 & 9 (wedding + funeral). Practise consult-style questions.

- ☐ **Day 7** — Chapter 10 (business). Re-read Quick Reference. Take a mock test.

*Every flower has its own personality.
The florist's job is to listen.*